

A Service of Prayer and Preaching
Fourth Sunday in Lent
March 22, 2020

Welcome to Worship! ‘ . . . I once was blind, but now I see,’ If John Newton’s hymn, “Amazing Grace,” had been in existence during the time of today’s Gospel Lesson, it is likely that the blind man in the story might have begun to sing it after Jesus restored his sight. The story goes beyond the fact that Jesus restored a man’s physical vision. It is also a good example of how Jesus rescues us from our spiritual blindness and allows us to see the beauty of His love and salvation for each one of us.

Welcome

Opening Hymn “Praise the One Who Breaks the Darkness” # 849

1 Praise the One who breaks the dark - ness With a lib - er -
2 Praise the One who blessed the chil - dren With a strong, yet
3 Let us praise the Word In - car - nate, Christ, who suf - fered
at - ing light; Praise the One who frees the pris - 'ners,
gen - tle, word; Praise the One who drove out de - mons
in our place. Je - sus died and rose vic - to - rious
Turn - ing blind - ness in - to sight. Praise the One who preached the
With the pierc - ing, two-edged sword. Praise the One who brings cool
That we may know God by grace. Let us sing for joy and
Gos - pel, Heal - ing ev - 'ry dread dis - ease, Calm - ing
wa - ter To the des - ert's burn - ing sand; From this
glad - ness, See - ing what our God has done; Let us
storms, and feed - ing thou - sands With the ver - y Bread of peace.
Well comes liv - ing wa - ter, Quench - ing thirst in ev - 'ry land.
praise the true Re - deem - er, Praise the One who makes us one.

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Opening Versicles

- [L]** This is the day the Lord has made;
[C] let us rejoice and be glad in it.

L From the rising of the Sun to its setting,
C the name of the Lord is to be praised.
L Return to the Lord, your God, for He is gracious and merciful
C slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and repents of evil.
L Jesus said: If any man would come after Me,
C let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me.
L Christ was wounded for our transgressions.
C He was bruised for our iniquities.
L From the rising of the sun to its setting,
C the name of the Lord is to be praised.
C Glory be to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit; as it was in the beginning, is now, and will be forever. Amen.

Confession and Absolution

P Let us then confess our sins to God our Father.
C Most merciful God, we confess that we are by nature sinful and unclean. We have sinned against you in thought, word and deed, by what we have done and by what we have left undone. We have not loved you with our whole heart; we have not loved our neighbors as ourselves. We justly deserve your present and eternal punishment. For the sake of your Son, Jesus Christ, have mercy on us. Forgive us, renew us, and lead us, so that we may delight in your will and walk in your ways to the glory of your holy name. Amen.
P In the mercy of almighty God, Jesus Christ was given to die for us, and for his sake God forgives us all our sins. To those who believe in Jesus Christ he gives the power to become the children of God and bestows on them the Holy Spirit. May the Lord, who has begun this good work in us, bring it to completion in the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.
C Amen.

Prayer of the Day

P Let us Pray: Almighty God, our heavenly Father, Your mercies are new every morning; and though we deserve only punishment, You receive us as Your children and provide for all our needs of body and soul. Grant that we may heartily acknowledge Your merciful goodness, give thanks for all Your benefits, and serve You in willing obedience; through Jesus Christ, Your Son, our Lord, who lives and reigns with You and the Holy Spirit, one God, now and forever.
C Amen.

Readings from Holy Scripture

First Lesson

Hosea 5:15-6:2

Then I will go back to my place until they admit their guilt. And they will seek my face; in their misery they will earnestly seek me." [6:1] "Come, let us return

to the Lord. He has torn us to pieces but he will heal us; he has injured us but he will bind up our wounds. [2] After two days he will revive us; on the third day he will restore us, that we may live in his presence.

L This is the Word of the Lord

C Thanks be to God.

Second Lesson

Romans 8:35-39

"Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword? [36] As it is written: "For your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered." [37] No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. [38] For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, [39] neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

L This is the Word of the Lord

C Thanks be to God.

Responsive Reading

L We have an advocate with the Father: Jesus Christ, the Righteous One.

C He was delivered up to death; He was delivered for the sins of the people.

L Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered.

C He was delivered up to death; He was delivered for the sins of the people.

L We have an advocate with the Father: Jesus Christ, the Righteous One.

C He was delivered up to death; He was delivered for the sins of the people.

Holy Gospel

John 9:1-7, 13-17, 34-39

As he went along, he saw a man blind from birth. [2] His disciples asked him, "Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?" [3] "Neither this man nor his parents sinned," said Jesus, "but this happened so that the work of God might be displayed in his life. [4] As long as it is day, we must do the work of him who sent me. Night is coming, when no one can work. [5] While I am in the world, I am the light of the world." [6] Having said this, he spit on the ground, made some mud with the saliva, and put it on the man's eyes. [7] "Go," he told him, "wash in the Pool of Siloam" (this word means Sent). So the man went and washed, and came home seeing. [13] They brought to the Pharisees the man who had been blind. [14] Now the day on which Jesus had

made the mud and opened the man's eyes was a Sabbath. [15] Therefore the Pharisees also asked him how he had received his sight. "He put mud on my eyes," the man replied, "and I washed, and now I see." [16] Some of the Pharisees said, "This man is not from God, for he does not keep the Sabbath." But others asked, "How can a sinner do such miraculous signs?" So they were divided. [17] Finally they turned again to the blind man, "What have you to say about him? It was your eyes he opened." The man replied, "He is a prophet." [34] To this they replied, "You were steeped in sin at birth; how dare you lecture us!" And they threw him out. [35] Jesus heard that they had thrown him out, and when he found him, he said, "Do you believe in the Son of Man?" [36] "Who is he, sir?" the man asked. "Tell me so that I may believe in him." [37] Jesus said, "You have now seen him; in fact, he is the one speaking with you." [38] Then the man said, "Lord, I believe," and he worshiped him. [39] Jesus said, "For judgment I have come into this world, so that the blind will see and those who see will become blind."

L This is the Gospel of the Lord.

C Praise to You, O Christ.

Sermon "Who Will Separate Us...?" Romans 8:35-39

Hymn

"God Bless Our Native Land" # 965

1 God bless our na - tive land; Firm may she ev - er stand
2 So shall our prayers a - rise To God a - bove the skies;

Through storm and night. When the wild tem - pests rave, Rul - er of
On Him we wait. Thou who art ev - er nigh, Guard-ing with

wind and wave, Do Thou our coun - try save By Thy great might.
watch-ful eye, To Thee a - loud we cry: God save the state!

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Apostle's Creed

I believe in God, the Father Almighty, Maker of heaven and earth.

And in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord, who was conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the virgin Mary, Suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died and was buried. He descended into hell. The third day he rose again from the dead. He ascended into heaven and sits at the right hand of God the Father almighty. From thence he will come to judge the living and the dead.

I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic Church, the communion of saints, the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen.

Prayers of the Church

The Lord's Prayer

Blessing and Benediction

L Let us Bless the Lord.

C **Thanks be to God.**

P The Lord bless you and keep you; The Lord make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you; The Lord look upon you with favor, and give you peace.

C **Amen.**